



Boat, Tent or Box - Schools of the World

When you got up this morning, you more than likely prepared yourself for a day at school. A school with brick walls, large windows, classrooms and a library. However, for millions of pupils around the globe, this 'school' is a distant dream and instead they receive their education on water, under canvas or even in a cave. Here are some of their stories.

Education - For Everyone

In developed countries, education is seen as a right to be enjoyed by all children and young adults. In many developing countries this is unfortunately not the case and education remains the privilege of the wealthy.

In 1985, teacher Inderjit Khurana decided to address the hundreds of street children living, begging and working around India's busy urban train stations. She saw that the children were just waiting around and decided to take advantage of this time. She started gathering them for storybook sessions and soon the children were motivated to learn to read independently. From eleven students, Khurana now has a foundation that runs twelve platform schools, job training and has helped over 6,000 children.

Similarly, children in the Cambodian slum Stung Mean Chey also have to work and therefore miss school. Collecting aluminium cans and other items can make about \$1 a day and so their parents are reluctant to let them skip work. Aided by Cambodian communities living abroad, Phymean Noun decided to set up a free school and, as an incentive to parents, the school offers free rice and a monthly allowance to families with children in school.

Learning - In a Cave?

Ever thought your school could do with a glow up? In the early 2000s, Dongzhong, a village in China found itself in the spotlight. Why? It was in a cave. Education and life in general were hard. No teachers wanted to work in the area as there was no electricity or running water. The school had little but made the most of its situation. A floor and roof were woven out of bamboo and, despite living and working with birds and bats flying overhead, the students studied hard. Once this incredible story made the press, many people sent supplies, money and aid, and the school prospered. However, its success ultimately was its undoing. The Chinese government disapproved of the portrayal of China's education system and so closed the school and built a traditional one, more like yours, nearby.



Photo by Shawna Pierson (CC BY 2.0) - (Cropped)

Flooded and Bombed

Haiti 2010. An earthquake kills 200,000 people in a single day and destroys half the schools. Despite this, the pupils continued learning in makeshift tent classrooms with the help of UNICEF initiative 'School in a Box'. This scheme sends a large box filled with all the essentials for making a mini school. These include workbooks, textbooks, pencils, rulers and even special blackboard paint to turn the lid of the box into a portable blackboard. While school might be the last place many teenagers would want to be in that situation, in times of crisis and war a school can offer a semblance of normality and a sense of hope. As well as victims of natural disasters, the School in a Box programme helps children in refugee camps, unable to access the local education system, to continue their education.

Learning in Monsoon Season: Bangladesh's Boat Schools

Established 2002

90 boats

Cover 250 km area of rivers swollen due to heavy rainfall in NW Bangladesh

Solar panels provide electricity

Each boat has four computers that connect to WiFi

30 – 35 pupils are offered education for 3 hours a day